

HMF Design Clinic Activity Guide

Everything a facilitator needs to run the Cedarline Hybrid Mesh Firewall clinic.

The mission

Today your team is the Cisco Solution Engineering team walking into Cedarline. You will sit with four real conversations, hear what is keeping them up at night, and answer as Solution Engineers do, with the right solution, why it fits, and the outcome it delivers, all brought together into one Hybrid Mesh Firewall design.

The scenario

Cedarline Health Group is a regional healthcare payer-provider with roughly 8,000 employees across four hospitals and thirty-one clinics, plus a claims-processing business that handles the money. Growth by acquisition (including a second data centre absorbed as-is) and a mid-flight, disorderly move to public cloud have left a fragmented security posture. After a security incident in March, the board asked what would have stopped it, and leadership still cannot answer. Budget and executive attention are approved but explicitly temporary, and the security team is small.

Learning objectives

- 1 Map Cedarline's stated concerns to the right Cisco Secure solutions.
- 2 Explain, in the customer's language, how each solution addresses the concern.
- 3 Connect the four case studies into one coherent Hybrid Mesh Firewall design.
- 4 Present the business outcome, not just the feature.

The four case studies

- 1 Case Study 1**
Cedarline is standing up AI across regulated workflows and public cloud faster than security can see it. Help them prove compliance, vet what they adopt, and get visibility and guardrails over AI traffic.
- 2 Case Study 2**
Workloads sprawl across AWS, Azure and on-prem, each with its own policy model. Contain lateral movement, prove consistent controls to auditors, and give Cedarline one place to define and enforce policy.
- 3 Case Study 3**
A mixed-vendor perimeter, an inherited rulebase and mostly encrypted traffic leave blind spots and a slow response. Restore visibility, speed the response, and modernise detection with the team they have.
- 4 Case Study 4**
A flat data centre and fragmented Kubernetes networking invite east-west movement. Build segmentation Cedarline can adopt safely, with runtime visibility and application-dependency awareness so nothing breaks.

How to run it (40 to 45 minutes)

- Each table forms a **team of 8**, split into **four pairs**. Give every team a **Workbook**.
- Each pair takes **one case study** (its four pain points) and works in parallel: identify the product from the cheat-strip, then write the SE response.
- The team reconvenes, each pair shares its case study, and the team agrees the answers.
- Combine everything into one **Hybrid Mesh Firewall topology**. Teams submit the diagram for **SME review**; it is reviewed, not scored.

Agenda

0 to 5 min	Facilitator sets the scene: read the scenario, explain the mission and how scoring works. Teams skim the product cheat-strip.
5 to 25 min	In four pairs, work one case study each (four pain points): identify the product, write the SE response.
25 to 35 min	Reconvene. Each pair presents its case study; the team agrees and captures the answers.
35 to 45 min	Combine into one HMF topology and prepare the readout.

Assign light roles in each team: a **timekeeper**, a **scribe** for the Workbook, and a **presenter** for the readout. Keep the room moving with a time check at 25 and 35 minutes.

How we score

Each pain point is scored across the three dimensions below: **Problem Identifier** out of 5, **Solution Designer** out of 10, and **Value Communicator** out of 10, for **25 per pain point**. Four pain points make a **case study score out of 100**, and the four case studies make an **overall score out of 400**. The topology diagram is **submitted for SME review**, not scored.

Problem Identifier OUT

OF 5

Correctly identified the customer's pain point and the requirements behind it.

Solution Designer OUT

OF 10

Recommended the right Cisco solution, architecture, and approach.

Value Communicator

OUT OF 10

Clearly explained how the solution works and the customer outcomes it enables.

Teams use the **HMF product cheat-strip** in the Workbook to identify products themselves; it is a uniform list with no pain-point give-aways. Facilitators grade each submitted Workbook against the **Grading Guide**, which gives a scoring rubric and the answer key for every pain point, and record the score and feedback on the **Proctor evaluation page** bound into the back of that team's Workbook: a score out of 100 with feedback for each case study, an overall score out of 400, and a note on what the team did well and where they can learn and grow.